

Popular App Launchers at Your Fingertips

For readers who have not used application launchers, now is the time to try one out. This article demonstrates the popular app launchers GNOME Do, GNOME Pie and Synapse. They are more powerful and faster than any built-in search system of an OS, and are capable of doing a lot more than just launching apps.



On a lazy Sunday afternoon, after eating a rather heavy lunch, I was getting ready to write yet another article. I pressed <Ctrl+Spacebar> and a grey window popped up. I started typing into it and had got only as far as 'lib' when the familiar icon of LibreOffice Writer came up. I hit the *Enter* key and leaned back in my chair, the scene harmonising with my already indolent mood. "Installing Synapse was a smart move," I thought to myself.

Synapse is a 'semantic launcher'. I've always felt that it is an incredibly dry description for an extremely useful program. Synapse is part of a category of software known as application launchers. Such software not only allows you to quickly access your favourite apps but often also includes powerful search functionality. Call it an over active imagination, but I always think of app launchers as

obsequious digital ferrets running around uncovering files, locating apps and placing them all at your fingertips.

Though there is no shortage of application launchers, I would like to review the three most popular ones – GNOME Do, GNOME Pie and Synapse.

History

GNOME Do was originally created by David Siegel. It was inspired by Quicksilver for the Mac OS X and GNOME Launch Box.

GNOME Pie was created by Simon Schneegans, a student of computer media science at the Bauhaus University in Weimar, Germany. He explained his reasons for creating another application launcher: "I realised the trend in application launchers to be keyboard based. All of them